

The secretary of state for science, innovation and technology was a secretary of state in the government of the United Kingdom, with responsibility for the Department for Science, Innovation and Technology. The incumbent was a member of the Cabinet of the United Kingdom.

Responsibilities

The responsibilities of the secretary of state included:

Online Safety Bill

Oversight of Science and Technology

Economic and national security

Skills and Talent

Landscape review

Research bureaucracy

Regulation

Overall R&D budget

Horizon Europe

Advanced Research and Invention Agency

UK Research and Innovation

OneWeb shareholding

British Technology Investments Ltd

History

In 1915 a Privy Council Committee for Scientific and Industrial Research' consisting at first of six ministers and three other privy councillors in their personal capacities was established.

Because of the close connection between education and research, the President of the Board

of Education was nominated as vice-president of the committee of the Privy Council. With the increasing importance of the industrial side of research, these initial arrangements soon became inadequate.

Consequently, in December 1916 a separate Department of Scientific and Industrial Research was created which headed by the lord president of the Council. In 1959 responsibility for science was given to a separate minister for science. The only holder of this office was Quintin Hogg (then 2nd Viscount Hailsham) who until October 1959 had been Lord President of the Council.

In 1964 the offices of Minister for Science and Minister of Education were merged to create the position of Secretary of State for Education and Science with Quintin Hogg remaining in post. From June 1970 to March 1974, this post was held by future Prime Minister Margaret Thatcher.

In 1992, the responsibility for science was transferred to the Office of Science and Technology initially based in the Cabinet Office. In 1995 responsibility was transferred to the secretary of state for trade and industry.

In 2007, under Gordon Brown's new premiership, the position of Secretary of State for Innovation, Universities and Skills was created, this role took over responsibility for science and innovation from the secretary of state for trade and industry and responsibility for higher education from the secretary of state for education and skills. In 2009 the responsibilities of the secretaries of state for business, enterprise and regulatory reform and innovation, universities and skills were merged to created the position of Secretary of State for Business, Innovation and Skills. In July 2016, Prime Minister Theresa May decided to merge the Department for Energy and Climate Change into this department resulting in the position being renamed to Secretary of State for Business, Energy and Industrial Strategy.

The current office was created by a government reshuffle on 7 February 2023, combining responsibilities from the Department for Business, Energy and Industrial Strategy with

responsibilities from the Department for Digital, Culture, Media and Sport and from the Government Office for Science. The department and secretary of state have responsibilities to "deliver improved public services, create new and better-paid jobs and grow the economy."

In May 2023 the position was incorporated as a corporation sole.

On 20 July 2026 it was merged with the Department for Business and Trade.

List

Minister for Science (1959–1964)

Colour key (for political parties):

Conservative

Secretary of State for Education and Science (1964–1992)

Colour key (for political parties):

Conservative

Labour

Secretary of State for Innovation, Universities and Skills (2007–2009)

Colour key (for political parties):

Labour

Secretary of State for Science, Innovation and Technology (2023–2026)

Colour key (for political parties):

Conservative

Labour

Secretary of State for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade (2026-present)

Colour key (for political parties):

Labour

Timeline

See also

Departments of the Government of the United Kingdom

Cabinet of the United Kingdom

Minister of State for Science, Research and Innovation

Shadow Secretary of State for Science, Innovation and Technology

== References ==